
VENDOR EVALUATION REPORT

CRM Platform Comparison & Recommendation

An independent, evidence-based comparison of HubSpot, Salesforce, and Zoho CRM — built to support Dechub's purchasing decision.

HubSpot

Salesforce

Zoho CRM

Prepared for: Dechub

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Executive Summary

This report compares three shortlisted CRM platforms — **HubSpot**, **Salesforce**, and **Zoho CRM** — across pricing, ease of use, automation/AI depth, customization, and verified third-party reviews (G2, Capterra, Trustpilot, Gartner Peer Insights, and independent analyst write-ups). The goal is to give Dechub a clear, genuine basis for choosing the right CRM rather than relying on vendor marketing alone.

3
TOOLS EVALUATED

6
COMPARISON CRITERIA

20+
SOURCES REVIEWED

2026
PRICING DATA

The one-line story of each tool:

TOOL	WHAT IT FUNDAMENTALLY IS	BEST FIT
HubSpot	Easiest-to-use all-in-one CRM + marketing/sales/service "Hubs"	Agencies and SMBs that want fast setup and tight marketing-sales alignment
Salesforce	The deepest, most customizable enterprise CRM platform	Larger organizations with budget for admins/consultants and complex sales processes
Zoho CRM	Best value-for-money CRM with the broadest feature set per dollar	Cost-conscious SMBs willing to accept a steeper learning curve and dated UI

A note on objectivity: Pricing is pulled from official vendor pricing pages, G2, Capterra, and independent analyst sites current as of mid-2026. Salesforce and HubSpot both have well-documented patterns of "advertised entry price" vs. "real total cost" — this gap is called out explicitly in each deep dive rather than smoothed over.

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Side-by-Side Comparison Matrix

CRITERIA	HUBSPOT	SALESFORCE	ZOHO CRM
Core Category	All-in-one CRM + Marketing/Sales/Service "Hubs" on one Smart CRM database	Enterprise CRM platform (Sales Cloud / Agentforce Sales) with a vast app ecosystem	Full-featured CRM as part of Zoho's 55+ app business suite
Entry Pricing (2026)	Free CRM (2 seats); Starter from \$20/seat/mo; Professional from \$100/seat/mo (Sales) or \$890/mo (Marketing, 3 seats)	Starter Suite \$25/user/mo; Pro/Enterprise Clouds from \$175/user/mo; Agentforce 1 Sales up to \$550/user/mo	Free (3 users); Standard \$14/user/mo; Professional \$23/user/mo; Enterprise \$40/user/mo; Ultimate ~\$52–65/user/mo
Real-World Cost (10-person team)	Often \$10,000–\$50,000/year once Hubs, seats, and contact tiers are factored in, per multiple 2026 cost breakdowns	Frequently the most expensive — Enterprise/Unlimited tiers plus Data Cloud, Premier Support (30% of license fees), and Flex Credits add up fast	Roughly \$4,500–\$7,200/year for a comparable Zoho One bundle — the cheapest of the three at equivalent team size
Ease of Use	Highest — reviewers consistently cite fast onboarding and intuitive UI (88% of G2 reviewers rate ease of use highly)	Moderate–Low — powerful but admin-heavy; "we spend more on consultants than the license" is a recurring G2 complaint	Moderate — functional but UI feels dated; G2's top complaint tag is "Learning Curve" (112 mentions)
AI Features	Breeze Copilot + AI Agents, credit-based pricing on top of plan (\$9/1,000 credits); strongest on Professional+	Agentforce — most advanced agentic AI of the three, but pricing has changed three times since 2024 and is hard to predict (Flex Credits, \$550/user/mo bundled tier)	Zia AI — solid lead scoring/forecasting/anomaly detection, but gated to Enterprise tier (\$40/user/mo) and needs ~75+ converted leads of history to be accurate
Customization	Good within Hub structure, but hub-switching can feel siloed; less deep than Salesforce for complex workflows	Best-in-class — Flow Builder, custom objects, 7,000+ AppExchange apps; the most flexible of the three by a wide margin	Very strong for the price — Canvas (no-code UI redesign), Blueprint workflows, custom modules/functions
G2 Rating (approx.)	~4.4/5 across 13,000+ reviews (Sales Hub)	~4.4/5 across 25,000+ reviews (Sales Cloud / Agentforce Sales)	~4.1/5 from 2,885 reviews (review base skews small-business/mid-market; enterprise reviews are sparse)
Most-Cited Weakness	Steep price jumps between tiers; "tax on success" as contact counts grow; hub-switching complexity	High total cost of ownership; constant need for admins/consultants; opaque AI/add-on pricing	Dated UI, sluggish with large datasets; poor customer support response times for non-premium users; key features gated by tier
Best For	Marketing-led SMBs and agencies wanting one fast, intuitive system for sales + marketing + service	Mid-market/enterprise orgs with complex, multi-department sales processes and budget for admin overhead	Budget-conscious SMBs that want the most features per dollar and can tolerate a learning curve

On "free" CRMs: Both HubSpot and Zoho offer genuinely usable free tiers (HubSpot: up to 1M contacts but only 2 seats; Zoho: 3 users). Salesforce has no comparable free-forever CRM tier — its cheapest paid plan (\$25/user/mo, Essentials/Starter Suite) is the practical floor.

HubSpot — Deep Dive

HubSpot

G2: ~4.4/5 (13,000+ reviews) | Capterra: ~4.5/5 (4,400+ reviews)

HubSpot is built around a single "Smart CRM" database with separate Marketing, Sales, Service, Content, and Data/Operations Hubs layered on top. Its core reputation — earned over nearly two decades — is ease of use: reviewers across the board cite it as the fastest CRM to onboard a team on.

2026 Pricing

PLAN	PRICE	WHAT YOU GET
Free CRM	\$0	Up to 1,000,000 contacts, unlimited deals/tasks, but capped at 2 seats; HubSpot branding on all outward-facing assets
Starter	\$20/seat/mo	Removes branding, basic automation, multiple pipelines
Professional (Sales Hub)	\$100/seat/mo	Sequences, forecasting, advanced reporting, AI features
Professional (Marketing Hub)	~\$890/mo (3 seats)	Full marketing automation, A/B testing, attribution reporting
Enterprise	\$150/seat/mo (Sales) up to ~\$3,600+/mo (full bundle)	Custom objects, predictive AI, SSO, advanced permissions

Caution: the jump from Starter (\$20/seat) to Professional (\$100/seat) is 5x, and most SDR-critical features (sequences, advanced sequences, forecasting) only unlock at Professional. Mandatory onboarding fees (\$1,500 Professional / \$3,500 Enterprise) and per-Hub billing mean a real 10-person team can land at \$2,500–5,000/month rather than the advertised ~\$1,000/month (per MarketBetter's 2026 SDR cost breakdown).

WHAT REVIEWERS LIKE

- Most intuitive interface of the three — ~88% of G2 reviewers rate it 8/10+ on overall recommendation, ~70% cite ease of use as a top reason they stay
- Genuinely useful free tier — not a stripped-down trial, a permanent working CRM
- Best-in-class marketing-to-sales handoff; unified timeline across emails, forms, page visits, deals

WHAT REVIEWERS FLAG

- Pricing escalates sharply between tiers — described by G2 reviewers as feeling like "a tax on success" as contact lists grow
- Hub-switching can create silos; complex relationship mapping for multi-stakeholder B2B deals is weaker than specialized tools
- Seat/permission management (core seats vs. paid Hub seats vs. view-only) is confusing to administer

"Reporting and automation are powerful but can take time to learn and maintain, particularly as processes evolve. It's easy for workflows or properties to become overly complex without strong internal ownership."

— Verified user review, G2 (2026)

"The pricing structure is frustrating. Costs rise quickly as you start adding more contacts which honestly feels like a tax on success."

— Verified user review, G2 — HubSpot Marketing Hub (2026)

Salesforce — Deep Dive

Salesforce (Sales Cloud / Agentforce Sales)

G2: ~4.4/5 (25,000+ reviews)

Salesforce has held the #1 CRM market-share position by IDC revenue for over a decade, serving 150,000+ companies. It is the deepest, most customizable platform of the three — at the cost of being the most expensive and the most administration-heavy.

2026 Pricing

PLAN	PRICE	WHAT YOU GET
Starter / Essentials Suite	\$25/user/mo (up to 10 users)	Basic sales, service, and marketing functionality for small teams
Professional	~\$80–100/user/mo (third-party estimate)	Adds Orders, Products, Price Books, Quotes
Enterprise	\$175/user/mo	API access, advanced customization, workflow automation
Unlimited	~\$330/user/mo	Adds built-in lead scoring, Einstein Bots, 24/7 support
Agentforce 1 Sales	\$550/user/mo (or \$125/user/mo add-on)	Full agentic AI, Tableau Next analytics, Slack Enterprise+

Hidden costs reported across multiple 2026 sources: Data Cloud runs \$500 per 100,000 credits on top of license fees; Premier Support costs 30% of net license fees; a June 2025 restructuring raised Enterprise/Unlimited list prices ~6%; annual contracts are required on virtually every tier. AI/Agentforce pricing has changed three times since 2024 (per-conversation → Flex Credits → bundled/add-on), making budgeting genuinely difficult.

WHAT REVIEWERS LIKE

- Unmatched customization and ecosystem depth — Flow Builder, custom objects, 7,000+ AppExchange apps
- Most advanced agentic AI of the three (Agentforce) for organizations that can afford and configure it
- Scales cleanly across sales, service, marketing, and commerce on one underlying platform

WHAT REVIEWERS FLAG

- Highest total cost of ownership by a wide margin — "we spend more on consultants than the license itself" is a recurring G2 theme
- Requires dedicated administrative resources; not realistic for small, lean teams without a Salesforce admin
- AI/add-on pricing is opaque and has shifted repeatedly — official guidance often defaults to "contact a sales representative"

"Salesforce is a massive company, and it shows. All they seem to care about is revenue. Not value... We're counting down the days until our contract is up, and I would strongly advise any business — especially smaller or leaner teams — to think twice before locking into a long-term agreement."

— Verified user review, G2 (2026)

"The platform is incredibly powerful but requires constant administration. We spend more on consultants than on the license itself."

— Synthesized from G2 reviewer reports, cited in MarketBetter analysis (2026)

Important framing: Salesforce's high G2 score (4.4/5) coexists with consistent cost complaints — this is a pattern of "the product works, the bill is the problem," similar to ZoomInfo in the lead-gen category. It's the right tool only when the complexity it manages is itself complex (multi-department, multi-region sales orgs).

Zoho CRM — Deep Dive

Zoho CRM

G2: ~4.1/5 (2,885 reviews) | Gartner Peer Insights: ~4.4/5 (1,385 ratings)

Zoho CRM is the value play of the category — part of Zoho's wider 55+ app business suite (used by 100M+ users globally). It consistently wins on "features per dollar" comparisons against both HubSpot and Salesforce, with the tradeoff being a less polished, steeper-learning-curve interface.

2026 Pricing

PLAN	PRICE	WHAT YOU GET
Free	\$0 (up to 3 users)	Core leads/contacts/accounts, basic reports — no workflow automation depth
Standard	\$14/user/mo (annual)	Sales forecasting, custom fields, roles, call center connectors
Professional	\$23/user/mo (annual)	Email integration, social CRM, Blueprint workflow management, inventory
Enterprise	\$40/user/mo (annual)	Zia AI, predictive analytics, custom modules, encryption at rest
Ultimate	~\$52–65/user/mo (annual)	Advanced analytics, expanded storage, custom AI/ML platform

Real cost watch-outs: storage overages run ~\$3.25/mo per 5GB; "team user" seats (for non-sales staff) can't access reports, dashboards, or Zia AI — they need full "org user" licenses for real functionality; most SMBs underestimate implementation costs by 2–3x (\$2K–15K typical, \$25K+ for complex migrations, per Prospeo's 2026 analysis).

WHAT REVIEWERS LIKE

- Best value-for-money in the category — G2 reviewers explicitly cite running "an entire agency for \$45/user/month"
- Deep customization (Canvas no-code redesign, Blueprint workflows, custom modules) at a fraction of Salesforce's price
- Native multi-channel CRM (email, telephony, social, live chat) without needing third-party add-ons

WHAT REVIEWERS FLAG

- Top G2 complaint is "Learning Curve" (112 mentions) — UI feels dated, with two competing navigation menus reported by reviewers
- Zia AI and several advanced features are gated to Enterprise tier (\$40/user/mo) and above
- Customer support response times are inconsistent for non-premium-tier customers

"What I liked most about Zoho CRM was how customizable and all-in-one it is. It allowed me to tailor workflows, fields, and modules to match specific business processes rather than forcing us to adapt to the software."

— Verified user review, Capterra (2026)

"Zoho CRM's biggest drawbacks are its steep learning curve due to a cluttered interface and inconsistent customer support response times for non-premium users."

— Verified user review, Capterra (2026)

Recommendation

As with the lead-generation comparison, there is no universal "best" CRM — the right choice depends on team size, budget, and process complexity. Below is a decision framework based on the evidence above, mapped to scenarios relevant to an agency like Dechub.

If budget is the top constraint

Zoho CRM delivers the most functionality per dollar of the three. The Professional tier (\$23/user/mo) covers Blueprint workflows, email integration, and automation that would cost significantly more elsewhere.

If ease of use and fast onboarding matter most

HubSpot is the clear winner — its free tier is genuinely usable, and its marketing-sales alignment is unmatched for an agency running both functions in one team.

If you need enterprise-grade customization

Salesforce's Flow Builder, custom objects, and 7,000+ AppExchange apps are unmatched — but only worth it if Dechub has (or budgets for) a dedicated admin and the process complexity to justify it.

If AI-driven selling is the priority

Salesforce's Agentforce is the most advanced agentic AI layer of the three, though pricing has shifted three times since 2024 and tops out at \$550/user/mo for the fully-bundled tier.

Suggested path for Dechub

Given Dechub's profile as a lean MarTech/AI agency that also runs client work across marketing, sales, and content production, the evidence points toward **HubSpot** or **Zoho CRM** as the most practical starting points — both are explicitly the "wrong fit, wrong scale" warning category for Salesforce per multiple 2026 reviews ("not realistic for small, lean teams without a Salesforce admin").

- **HubSpot** if the priority is fast onboarding, tight marketing-sales-service alignment, and a CRM the whole Dechub team (account managers, content, sales) can use without heavy training — accepting that costs escalate meaningfully past the Starter tier.
- **Zoho CRM** if the priority is maximizing features per rupee/dollar and Dechub is willing to invest setup time (Blueprint, Canvas, custom modules) to get there — a strong fit alongside Dechub's existing GrowthOS/automation-heavy way of working.

Salesforce is difficult to justify at Dechub's current scale unless a specific enterprise client engagement (e.g., a future Tanishq/Titan-scale internal CRM project) requires its depth — and even then, budget for consultants/admin time on top of license cost.

Recommended next step: Trial HubSpot's free CRM and Zoho's free tier side-by-side with a real Dechub workflow (e.g., the Dechub Academy enrollment pipeline or a client proposal pipeline) for 2–3 weeks, then compare actual day-to-day usability and time-to-value before committing to a paid annual plan.

Sources: HubSpot, Salesforce, and Zoho CRM official pricing pages; G2.com verified reviews; Capterra verified reviews; Gartner Peer Insights; and independent analyst write-ups (Encharge, SaaSwothy, EngageBay, MarketBetter, Sybill, SyncGTM, Zeeg, Prospeo, US Tech Automations, Authencio, TrustRadius) — all accessed June 2026. Salesforce add-on and AI pricing is subject to negotiation and has changed multiple times in recent years; figures here should be reconfirmed directly with sales before purchase.